Ratan opined that though the ‘domestic market may not require such product capabilities’, the company should ‘lead the way and give the Indian customer vehicles of superior performance, safety and reliability’. In 1990, at the company AGM, he reiterated this commitment. He said: ‘Enterprises in India will need to take a global view and condition themselves to providing goods and services of international standards in a competitive market.’ In a few years he would also look at associating with Daimler-Benz to give Indian customers highly superior cars.

The emphasis on quality was also necessary for the success of his strategy to establish new markets in ‘Africa, the Middle East and the Far East’ and for which he advocated an ‘aggressive’ approach. To promote exports, Ratan emphasized the need to give ‘special focus’ to ‘Value Engineering’, the objective of which was to reduce the ‘cost of vehicles, through design and material optimisation’. These efforts would yield rich dividends in the ensuing decades.

Soon after succeeding Moolgaokar, he unveiled his dream of developing and producing a ‘full-fledged passenger car’. Giving wings to this dream, in 1991, TELCO launched Tata Sierra, the company’s first sports utility vehicle (SUV). But times were difficult. With liberalization, ‘the overall market for automotive products’ produced in India had contracted. This not only hit the demand for passenger cars but also affected the sales of light commercial vehicles. Ratan’s answer to the new challenge was to aggressively implement the restructuring programme and its most relevant pillars in TELCO.

He worked towards making the company ‘more cost-efficient and more productive’, paying ‘greater attention to total quality’. Simultaneously, he underscored the ‘need to be more aggressive in the domestic and in international markets with a special focus on customer satisfaction’. These were, in essence, the main pillars of his restructuring plan that would meet the new challenges that the liberalized ecosystem threw up.

To improve quality, Ratan also proposed ‘technical collaboration or joint ventures abroad for the assembly and sale of vehicles’. It was not the first attempt made by TELCO to give Indian customers superior commuting comforts. In 1985, it had entered into a collaboration agreement with the Japanese Honda Motor Company Limited for the manufacture of their famous Accord model of cars in India. The version planned to be produced in India would have been more ‘commodious and fuel efficient’. But the